

Policy Analysis Fundamentals

Learner guide | SWP-028 | School of Social Policy & Advocacy

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Policy Analysis Fundamentals. By the end of the course, you should be able to analyse a policy's intent, implementation, stakeholders, and effects on communities.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Analyse a policy's intent, implementation, stakeholders, and effects on communities.
- Apply the key ideas from Policy basics.
- Apply the key ideas from Analytical framework.
- Apply the key ideas from Communicating analysis.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Policy basics	policy cycle, actors, evidence, values, and social-work roles	10 to 15 minutes
2. Analytical framework	problem definition, target population, benefits/burdens, feasibility, and equity	10 to 15 minutes
3. Communicating analysis	policy brief structure, recommendations, evidence use, and ethical advocacy	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Policy basics

This module focuses on policy cycle, actors, evidence, values, and social-work roles. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Policy cycle
- Actors
- Evidence
- Values
- Social-work roles

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of policy basics in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of policy cycle, actors, evidence, values, and social-work roles. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through policy basics safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Analytical framework

This module focuses on problem definition, target population, benefits/burdens, feasibility, and equity. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Problem definition
- Target population
- Benefits/burdens
- Feasibility
- Equity

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of analytical framework in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of problem definition, target population, benefits/burdens, feasibility, and equity. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through analytical framework safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Communicating analysis

This module focuses on policy brief structure, recommendations, evidence use, and ethical advocacy. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Policy brief structure
- Recommendations
- Evidence use
- Ethical advocacy

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of communicating analysis in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of policy brief structure, recommendations, evidence use, and ethical advocacy. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through communicating analysis safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: policy cycle.
- Review the distinction between: equity analysis.
- Review the distinction between: evidence.
- Review the distinction between: recommendations.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.